

Ludwig Mies van der Rohe

The German-born Mies van der Rohe (1886–1969), who became one of America's foremost practitioners of modernism, began his career as an apprentice to Behrens in 1912 before opening his own practice in Berlin. His pioneering buildings made use of new materials, such as steel frames and glass, with extreme clarity; describing his style as 'skin and bones', he discarded ornament and opened up interior spaces. In his German Pavilion at the Barcelona Exhibition of 1929, he created a geometric arrangement of green glass, chrome columns and marble, onyx and travertine planes. His two-storey Tugendhat House (1930) features a sweeping wall of glass and onyx and ebony screens. In 1927, Mies organized the exhibition *Die Wohnung*, which showcased the best modernist thinking on the problems of social housing. He directed the Bauhaus from 1930 to 1933, then emigrated in 1938 to the United States. His influential Seagram Building (1958) in New York helped to inaugurate a new era of simple, tall buildings that showed off their structural elements rather than camouflaging them with superfluous decoration.



Farnsworth House in Plano Illinois, Van der Rohe, 1945–51